

UX for product managers

A basic course to illuminate Product Managers on their path to become better.



Luisja Álvarez

Follow

Apr 17 · 6 min read ★

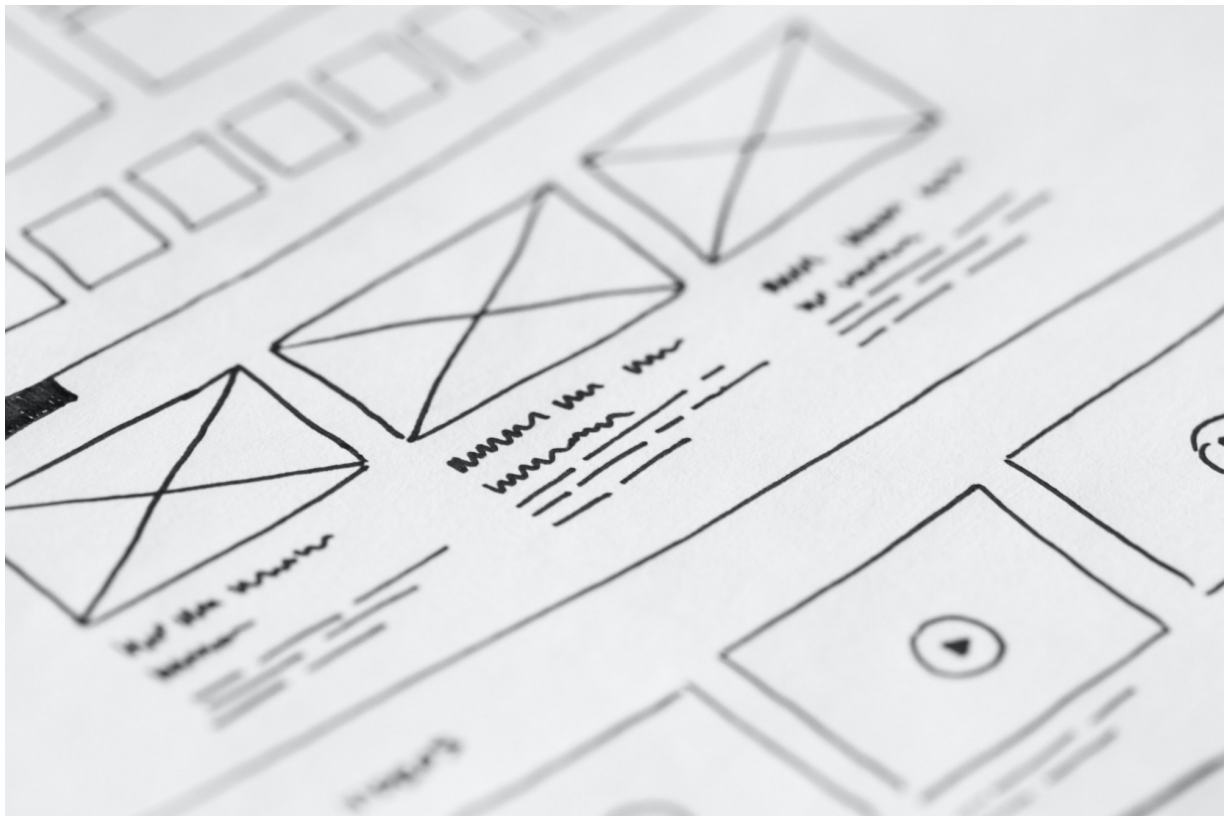


Photo by picjumbo.com

Today I feel like a reporter just because I'm writing about

something that happened this same morning. It's new. It's exciting.

For some time now, every quarter we perform a retrospective within the Global Product team at Telefonica CX. My main aim with this is to identify the top issues that concern and worry our Product Managers. With their direct feedback, I can tackle the most important problems we face or come up with ideas to improve their working environment (even their life).

One of the things that came up lately is that we (I) weren't focusing enough in career development and learning. Heard. And acted upon. We created a Learning initiative with the following tracks:

- **Product Talks:** people from other Product teams join us in an informal, open chat. They share with us their day-to-day as Product Managers, so we can learn what other companies and other top-performing teams are doing to ship products.
- **Online courses:** identify which courses we can find online, free or with a small cost, that will truly help the team grow, learn new things that help them in their daily work. We will share what we learn, and that way we can all profit from it.
- **Knowledge sharing:** an initiative where people from our own team will teach us what they know. From UX, to organizing meetings, even just writing posts...

Let's focus on the last one for now. Our dear teammate Laura Andina, Product Manager, formerly Head of UX of our incredible Product and Design team, agreed to help our PMs grow by sharing her own knowledge (she's writing this post with me, by the way). And, two birds, we also learn more about our designers' work, how to talk to them and provide feedback, what's the best way to design, to identify solutions to customer problems.

Why UX? Well, it's important to improve every skill if you want to be the best Product Manager you can be. But from the feedback we got from our own team, they're more worried about UX than UI because *"bad UX ruins the experience, bad UI only hurts a little to the eye"*.

. . .

So what did Laura teach us?

Well, she basically started by explaining the basics of what a designer is, and the different types of designers we could encounter in our careers. However, she put this in a way we Product Managers can understand without knowing the details of the craft, and relate better to these definitions. Just as the initial slide said, UX for dummies Product Managers.

"Designers are empathic problem solvers"

who are skilled at aligning business, customer, and employee needs within a specific context”

Basically, they need to understand the business case, the fit of the feature in the organization, and the value the solution should bring to our customer. And in that wide range, we can find:

- **Graphic designers:** someone who combines text and pictures in advertisements, magazines, or books. We don't interact with many of these.
- **Service designers:** they worry more about the Customer Experience than the User Interaction. An example for good service design is how Apple designs its stores (they look more like museums, or modern bars) compared to any regular cashier-based grocery store.
- **Interaction designer:** they are concerned with helping users achieve business and their own (user) goals. For example, if an interaction designer needs to design the interface for the cashier screen at a fast food restaurant, they'll need to understand who the user is (the agent taking the order and handling the payment), how they'll interact with other actors (the customer), and also understand the business (a fast food restaurant needs to speed up the ordering process and payment, in order to have the higher

rotation of customers they can manage).

- **UX researcher:** they'll work on understanding the customer problem we want to solve with more detail, and test different solutions and approaches. Product Managers identify the problem, UX researchers help understand it better.
- **Visual designer:** they worry about visual coherence, branding, colors,...it should always be the final step of the design process. They'll also generate the assets for engineers, validate the UI that we're shipping our customers,...and it's also where Product Managers most times can add little value.
- **UX writer:** they write for user experience. Their texts need to be clear, concise and useful. It's different from a regular copywriter, as they'll most likely "use sexy words to attract customers".
- **Product designer:** someone who is skilled enough in each category that can perform the whole design process. From understanding the problem, conducting research to gather insights from customers, to coming up with solutions, validating them, or even designing the UI and generating the assets for development. Even measuring the performance of the product and making corrections! The whole package.

And here, the eternal question in our field came up...

. . .

What is the difference between a Product Designer and a Product Manager?

Well, there's basically little, but Product Designers are more oriented on designing and building a particular solution, whilst Product Managers will impact more strategically, in a wider range of the product. Product Managers will set the vision and prioritize which problems to tackle, Product Designers tangibilize the solutions for those problems. What's for sure, is that there will have to be a lot of collaboration and discussions between them. Which is good, right?

If you want to read more about this subject, check out our own Senior Product Manager Silvia López Serra's post "*Product and Design: Who does what?*".

How-to: design 101

Our course continues and Laura teaches us what we need to understand to design better. The theory is pretty simple.

Problem. Problem. Problem. Find the problem, define it very well. Ask the following questions:

- Which problem are we solving?
- What previous information, insights, etc. do we have?

- What's our business team point of view?
- Why is this problem relevant?
- What's the goal of what we need to/want to solve?
- Any constraints we need to take into consideration?

“We can help our designers a lot by defining the problem very well”

Before placing the sofa, deciding its color, or the drapes', we first need to design our new house's blueprint. And for that, we first define the problem and scope it, then we'll tackle the user's flow, and once we have that, we can start tackling user interface. Or else, you'll end up like this:



Questions to ask to challenge the design

Today we learnt that we need to be *trolls* with the design. Challenge it. Find the places where it falls down, where it won't accomplish what we need it to: business and user needs.

Questions that help:

- What's the first thing the customer sees? Where do they land?
- What does the user see when that info isn't available? (Zero/Empty cases)
- What happens when there's just a little content?
- What about when there's way too much content? (Edge cases)
- If the user leaves while doing the process, what happens? Can they go back? What happens if they do?
- What's the business profit from this design?
- What's the user profit from this design?

Hands-on approach

The most fun part. I always say that the best way to learn how to run is to "*read a little, run a lot*". And Laura's approach with our Product Managers was today. We split up in groups, got a real-world problem assigned, and UX-ed a solution for it. The questions we need to provide an answer to:

1. Identify the core **business and user problem** that this feature needs to solve.
2. **List the constraints** we need to take into account.
3. Set the **main goal** our flow should have.
4. Define where our product should be placed in order to achieve our goals.
5. **Design a flow.**

It was great to watch a group of Product Managers put on the designer shoes and discuss a potential solution following a good design process. And a lot of fun for yet-another “confinement Friday”.

Our key takeaways

If you're a Product Manager, you're basically thinking the same thing we thought: how can we collaborate or co-exist when our roles are so similar? These are the 2 things we took away from today's session:

1. We now have a better understanding of our teammates' role, thus helping us empathize more with them, creating a better environment to collaborate.
2. Product Managers will focus much more on defining the problem and providing context. We can help our designers a lot by defining the problem very well.

By the way! This was **the first of two sessions**. Keep posted to know what happens on the second one :)

[Product Management](#)[Learning](#)[Design](#)[Product Design](#)[Product Development](#)

Discover Medium

Welcome to a place where words matter. On Medium, smart voices and original ideas take center stage - with no ads in sight. Watch

Make Medium yours

Follow all the topics you care about, and we'll deliver the best stories for you to your homepage and inbox. Explore

Become a member

Get unlimited access to the best stories on Medium — and support writers while you're at it. Just \$5/month. Upgrade

[About](#)[Help](#)[Legal](#)